12

MAKING SENSE OF REACTIONS TO COMMUNAL VIOLENCE IN MYANMAR

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In June 2012 the rape and murder of a Buddhist girl in Western Rakhine State sparked reprisals against Muslim communities. The resulting cycles of communal violence in the following months left hundreds dead, and thousands displaced. The tensions in Rakhine State continued through 2012, and by early 2013 the violence began to spread to other areas of the country. In Meiktila, in the country's central dry zone, a dispute in a jewellery store saw an escalation of violence and the burning of significant parts of the Muslim quarter, including mosques and schools. Through the rest of 2013 tensions remained high, and there continued to be isolated incidents of violence, especially in Rakhine State.

In October 2013, Mishal Husain interviewed Daw Aung San Suu Kyi on the BBC's *Today* programme. When asked about growing communal conflict between Buddhists and Muslims in Myanmar, Suu Kyi responded, "This is what the world needs to understand: that the fear is not just on the side of the Muslims, but on the side of the Buddhists as well. Yes, Muslims